

CHARLIE "BLACKCAT" SMITH

Interactive fire sculptor · metal fabricator · Sparseland Studios · Atlanta, GA

"UNCLE CHARLIE" · CONTRAPTIONISM · THE JOHNNY APPLESEED OF BURNING MAN

ABOUT

Charlie "Blackcat" Smith builds giant interactive fire contraptions — kinetic metal effigies that burn wood, breathe flame, and only come alive when a crowd shows up to rock them. For nearly 30 years he has turned welding workshops into art and strangers into a tribe around the fire: a multi-time Burning Man honorarium artist, AfrikaBurn instigator, and tireless community builder known as "the Johnny Appleseed of Burning Man."

AT A GLANCE

BASED

Atlanta, GA — Sparseland Studios

EDUCATION

BFA, Atlanta College of Art (1992)

MEDIUM

Steel & stainless; wood-fired + LPG flame effects; kinetic, rideable, crowd-powered

BURNING MAN

Honorarium artist: 2000, '05, '07, '08, '12, '17, '18

FESTIVALS

AfrikaBurn (instigator), Love Burn (co-producer), Hulaween, Bonnaroo, Okeechobee, Dubai

PRACTICE

Community-built workshops; licensed flame-effects operator; full Leave No Trace

SELECTED WORKS

- 2000** HEARTH
- 2005** Synapses Tour — 6 cities
- 2007** Contraptions · AfrikaBurn
- 2008** The Fleebie Flobber
- 2012** 24/7 Time Star
- 2017** Ganesha
- 2018** Uncle Charlie's Red Hot Cock
- 2024** The Gantry
- 2026** The Burning Book of Brian

NOW — BURNING MAN 2026

The Burning Book of Brian: a community-built memorial to writer Brian Doherty (This Is Burning Man) — an open steel book with a human heart that beats fire. One-time burn.